

The past perfect

Learner workbook

Show what had happened before another past point.

Understand the distinction

Form the past perfect with had + past participle: had left, had seen, had finished. It looks back from a past reference point to an earlier event or state.

Use it when the order or earlier background matters. It is not required for every earlier event if before, after, or context already makes the sequence clear. The negative is had not + participle; a question begins with Had + subject.

Compare the patterns

EARLIER EVENT

The train had left when I arrived.

The departure happened before the arrival.

EARLIER STATE

I had never visited before that trip.

Look back from the time of the trip.

QUESTION

Had you booked before you called?

Had comes before the subject.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Complete: She had ___ before I arrived. (leave)

2. What happened first: I had eaten when the guests arrived?

3. Is past perfect always required after after?

Use it in your own life

Describe arriving too late for something.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. left

Use the past participle after had.

2. I ate first.

Had eaten places the meal before the arrival.

3. No. After can already make the order clear.

After I finished, I left is natural.

One possible response

When I reached the shop, it had already closed.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-26.html